

DOMESTIC DRUDGERY
Sanya Malhotra in a still from Mrs.

CINEMA

SOMETHING'S COOKING

Actress Sanya Malhotra shines in *Mrs.*, the Hindi remake of the 2021 Malayalam drama, *The Great Indian Kitchen*

In 2021, a Malayalam film dropped on OTT and struck a touchy nerve with women over what was either their lived reality or their worst nightmare come alive. That Jeo Baby's brutal kitchen drama, *The Great Indian Kitchen*, came in the midst of the pandemic, when everyone was cloistered in their homes, only aggravated the torment its leading lady (Nimisha Sajayan) was put through. Sanya Malhotra remembers watching and being inspired by Sajayan's class act and also "feeling trapped, uncomfortable, moved and irritated".

In *Mrs.*, a Hindi adaptation of the acclaimed drama, which released on ZEE5 recently, Sanya hopes to evoke these feelings with her portrayal of a new bride who is overwhelmed with the demands in the kitchen. Going by the response to the trailer on her social media, she has partially succeeded as women wrote to her calling the film "triggering".

What made *The Great Indian Kitchen* particularly remarkable is how it busted the imagery of savouring food in cinema. The art of preparing food instead of giving pleasure became a source of distress and disgust when consumed. "The film makes you realise that somewhere we have been putting women on a pedestal," says Sanya. "This '*maa ke haath ka khaana, usse hi pet bharta hai*' [Only food cooked by a mother is wholesome], that the way to one's heart is through the stomach, are all romanticised notions. Cooking is truly a life skill and everyone should know how to cook and nourish themselves."

Mrs. is yet another female-fronted feature in Sanya's cap, the others being *Pagglait* (2021) and *Kathal* (2023), both Netflix releases. For the actor, the films have given her the opportunity to play the kind of women she has always wanted to portray on screen, ones that "feel confident and empowered".

Mrs., streaming on ZEE5, is Sanya's yet another female-fronted feature after Pagglait (2021) and Kathal (2023)

More recently, though, the actor went viral for depicting those emotions in Sunidhi Chauhan's track 'Aankh'. Sanya wows in the music video with her impeccable moves and swagger that is reminiscent of Beyoncé. Apart from showcasing her underexplored terpsichorean talent, it also allowed her to change her look, which entailed losing four kilos and dropping the familiar girl-next-door act for a more sensuous one.

Mrs. and 'Aankh' are also not the last we will see of the actress in 2025. The *Dangal* actress also has a Dharma romcom—*Sunny Sanskari ki Tulsi Kumari*—with Varun Dhawan, Janhvi Kapoor and Rohit Saraf; slice-of-life comedy *Toaster* on Netflix alongside Rajkummar Rao; and an Anurag Kashyap-directed thriller. Says Sanya, "I feel quite satisfied and extremely grateful at how my career is shaping up. It's all happening very organically. I'm not rushing through any of it." ■

–Suhani Singh